

SHANKAR



A Holiday Lesson

A private-public initiative involves foreign tourists to help change the lives of underprivileged children

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Twinkle twinkle little star. On the sandy shores of the obscure village of Muthana in Varkala—one of the hottest tourist destinations in God's Own Country—three-year-olds are reciting the nursery rhyme with a clarity that could put even adults to shame. The children come from the lowest rungs of society and attend the local Government-run pre-school. They are the beneficiaries of a private-public participatory initiative launched by Kerala Travels Interserve—a private tourism operator—jointly with the state Child Welfare Department and Health Action for People (HAP), an NGO. An experiment in 'responsible tourism', Lullaby@Varkala, a project launched two years ago, envisages active participation by foreign tourists to help transform the lives of the 3,200-odd children under the 150-odd childcare centres—called Anganwadis—by teaching them English and Math, in addition to providing them daily meals, uniforms, toys and books.

"We want to disprove the notion that tourism is an elitist activity which does not benefit the local community. These are the only Anganwadis in the state equipped with computers and where all kids wear uniforms," says



K.C. Chandrasenan of Kerala Travels. Over Rs 70 lakh has been spent on the project so far. Every participating tourist spends \$20 (Rs 800) a day. Small merchants have also benefited from the project. "We take the tourists to the small restaurants and shops, not to the five-star places," says C.R. Soman, of HAP, which has compiled a database of Anganwadi children to monitor their health needs.

"Interacting with the local community has been a learning experience for us. The holiday has given us an opportunity to help the needy," says Marylene Dutuis, a French language teacher at the Lincoln School of Science and Technology, based in Lincolnshire, UK, who comes here with batches of students. "We want to learn a Malayalam song from the children before we return to England," says Emma, one of the 15 students who have arrived this year to participate in Lullaby@Varkala. Over 600 tourists have attended the programme so far. This year on, Harold Goodwin, director, International Centre for Responsible Tourism at Greenwich University, will send volunteers from his group, 'People and Places'. So far, the underprivileged have been getting the short end of the tourism stick, but with the effort at responsible tourism finding new champions, this is all set to change, and for good. ■